

Penn State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-20 ceiling with unusually high transition risk: the model/poll consensus is strong and QB Rocco Becht provides quarterback stability.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 18 (482 points) · SP+ No. 17
Returning production	52% (No. 69) overall · Off. 50% (No. 80) · Def. 53% (No. 68)
Primer power rating	+16.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	9.0 wins · most likely 9-3
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better projected overall, but via reconstruction rather than continuity: Campbell/Becht and a large imported core raise the ceiling after 7-6, while the number of NFL and portal departures creates a wider failure band than a normal top-20 team.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Matt Campbell and OC/TE Taylor Mouser bring a personnel-adaptive offense built around transfer QB Rocco Becht and a large Iowa State skill-position nucleus, while DC D'Anton Lynn rebuilds the defense around returners such as LB Tony Rojas plus incoming LB Kooper Ebel and S Jeremiah Cooper.

Bottom line: Penn State has enough quarterback/staff continuity within the imported Campbell ecosystem to rebound sharply from 7-6, but this is a top-20 projection with medium-low evaluation confidence because both sides of the ball depend heavily on newcomers.

Beats expectations if: Becht and Mouser transplant their shared offensive language quickly, the new OL five becomes functional before USC/Michigan, and Lynn's transfer-heavy defense replaces the lost NFL/portal production without a major early efficiency drop.

Disappoints if: The 52% returning-production signal proves more predictive than the recognizable transfer names, the rebuilt line suppresses explosive offense, and the defense cannot replace its draft/portal losses before the contender games arrive.

Five things to remember

- ♦ **New staff:** HC Matt Campbell is a new external hire, and OC Taylor Mouser followed from Iowa State as the 2026 offensive play-caller.
- QB stability:** QB Rocco Becht transferred from Iowa State and is the established QB1, giving the rebuild a much firmer quarterback foundation than its overall continuity numbers suggest.
- NFL departures:** Penn State has 17 professional departures, including QB Drew Allar, RB Nicholas Singleton, RB Kaytron Allen, OL Olaivavega Ioane, EDGE Dani Dennis-Sutton, DL Zane Durant and S Zakee Wheatley, before material portal losses.
- ♦ **Roster overhaul:** Returning production is only 52% overall (No.69), 50% offense (No.80) and 53% defense (No.68), so both sides rely heavily on newcomers.
- Top-20 baseline:** Despite the 7-6 2025 record, the preseason consensus is tightly aligned around top-20 quality: SP+ No.17, AP No.18 and 9.0 projected wins.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (3-6 Big Ten)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	31.0 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	362.0 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	174.4 YPG · 4.8 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	7.19 YPA · 16 TD / 7 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	43.6%	● Very good
Scoring defense	20.5 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	326.8 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	142.5 YPG · 4.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	184.2 YPG · 6.54 YPA · 16 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Penn State scored 31.0 pts/g despite No. 85 total offense; the defense ranked No. 25 total/No. 31 scoring but was less impressive against the run and by pass efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.22 · No. 31	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.117 · No. 24	● Very good
Off. success rate	47.2% · No. 26	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	11.3% · No. 93	● Below average
Havoc allowed	13.5% · No. 41	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+3.24 · No. 36	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.041 · No. 47	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	41.1% · No. 63	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.8% · No. 64	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	15.9% · No. 63	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Offense was efficient (No. 24 EPA, No. 26 success) but not explosive (No. 93). Defense was good rather than elite by adjusted/play-level measures, so the 2026 rebuild is not replacing an untouchable baseline.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Matt Campbell - from Iowa State HC	● ↑ Raises the reset ceiling; imported familiarity reduces some transition risk
OC / play-caller	◆ Taylor Mouser - from Iowa State OC/TE	● ↑ Shared system with Campbell and QB Rocco Becht is a major stabilizer
DC	◆ D'Anton Lynn - from USC DC	● ↔ Proven coordinator leading a personnel-heavy defensive rebuild

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Rocco Becht	Iowa State	● ↑ Established QB1 and the most important continuity bridge into Campbell/Mouser's offense.
◆ RB Carson Hansen	Iowa State	● ↔ First-unit/top-rotation back in a room replacing two NFL draftees.
◆ RB James Peoples	Ohio State	● ↔ High-upside major rotation option who helps rebuild the RB room without erasing the loss of Singleton/Allen.
◆ TE Benjamin Brahmer	Iowa State	● ↑ Another first-unit TE with Mackey recognition and direct system familiarity.

Out	To	Loss
QB Drew Allar	NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 3, No. 76	● ↓ Starting-QB experience leaves; Becht meaningfully limits the replacement risk but does not erase the composition change.
RB Nicholas Singleton	NFL (Tennessee), Round 5, No. 165	● ↓ Major backfield loss.
RB Kaytron Allen	NFL (Washington), Round 6, No. 187	● ↓ Second major backfield loss makes Hansen/Peoples immediately consequential.
OL Olaivavega Ioane	NFL (Baltimore), Round 1, No. 14	● ↓ First-round line loss is the clearest reason to avoid assuming immediate OL continuity.
OL Drew Shelton	NFL (Dallas), Round 4, No. 112	● ↓ Another high-end OL departure in a rebuilt front.
WR Trebor Peña	NFL (Jacksonville), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material receiver production departs along with several other WRs who left for NFL opportunities.

Offensive net: ● ↔ The imported QB/skill core gives the offense a viable top-20 path, but the OL and proven-production turnover make the unit less stable than the headline names imply.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Kooper Ebel	Iowa State	● ↑ First-unit linebacker with Butkus recognition and direct staff familiarity.
◆ S Jeremiah Cooper	Iowa State	● ↑ Major secondary addition with Bednarik recognition.
◆ DE Ikenna Ezeogu	Iowa State	● ↔ Current first-unit end in a front replacing multiple high-end departures.
◆ DT Siale Taupaki	UCLA	● ↔ First-unit tackle and necessary interior replacement piece.

Out	To	Loss
DE Dani Dennis-Sutton	NFL (Green Bay), Round 4, No. 120	● ↓ Major edge departure.
DT Zane Durant	NFL (Buffalo), Round 5, No. 181	● ↓ High-value interior departure.
S Zakee Wheatley	NFL (Carolina), Round 5, No. 151	● ↓ Significant safety loss in a secondary that also saw portal turnover.
DB A.J. Harris	Indiana	● ↓ Material secondary transfer loss.
LB Amare Campbell	Tennessee	● ↓ Meaningful linebacker transfer loss alongside Dominic DeLuca's NFL departure.

Defensive net: ● ↔ A credible B-range rebuild rather than a continuity defense: Lynn has enough imported/returning talent for a top-25 result.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Personnel-adaptive Campbell/Mouser offense rather than a fixed formation claim.	Quarterback/staff familiarity, efficient 2025 Penn State baseline, TE depth and multiple credible backs.	Rebuilt OL and a receiver room replacing multiple professional departures; 2025 explosiveness was already only No.93.
Defense	Lynn-led rebuild combining returners such as LB Tony Rojas with imported Iowa State pieces and transfer DL help.	Enough high-end recognition/first-unit talent for a top-25 model projection.	Large NFL/portal losses across every level and only No.68 defensive returning production.
Special teams	Model strength led by a recognized kicker, with less detail than offense/defense.	SP+ special teams No.6 and Lou Groza watchlist K Ryan Barker.	Do not overstate unit certainty from the model alone; primary LS Tyler Duzansky departed to the NFL.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Rocco Becht brings established Power 4 starting experience and direct system familiarity.
RB	● B+	● ↓	Medium	RB Carson Hansen/RB James Peoples give quality options, but two NFL-drafted backs departed.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	The room is rebuilt around imported options after multiple professional departures.
TE	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Benjamin Brahmer brings system familiarity and Mackey recognition into a deep room.
OL	● B-	● ↓	Low	The final five remains unsettled after major turnover; C Brock Riker is the clearest anchor.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	Transfer reinforcements help, but the front is replacing extensive NFL/portal production.
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium	LB Tony Rojas returns and LB Kooper Ebel adds quality, balancing major turnover elsewhere.
Secondary	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	S Jeremiah Cooper adds high-end talent, but the back end is replacing several major departures.
Special teams	● A-	● ↔	Medium	SP+ rates the unit No. 6 and K Ryan Barker carries Groza recognition.
Coaching	● B+	● ↑	Medium-low	HC Matt Campbell and OC Taylor Mouser import shared system continuity, but the full reset adds risk.
Overall	● B+	● ↑	Medium-low	Top-20 model quality with QB/system continuity, offset by unusually low roster continuity.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Rocco Becht (TR: Iowa State)	QB	● High-end Power 4 starter / system anchor	Maxwell	Established QB1 and the central continuity bridge between Campbell/Mouser and a heavily rebuilt roster.
◆ Kooper Ebel (TR: Iowa State)	LB	● High-end conference starter	Butkus	First-unit linebacker and one of the most important imported defenders.
◆ Jeremiah Cooper (TR: Iowa State)	S	● High-end secondary addition	Bednarik	Major secondary piece in a back end replacing Zakee Wheatley, A.J. Harris and other departures.
◆ Benjamin Brahmer (TR: Iowa State)	TE	● High-end conference tight end	John Mackey	First-unit TE with direct system familiarity and a prominent role in Mouser’s offense.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Tony Rojas	LB	● High-upside returning defensive core piece	-	Returned to practice after missing spring work and projects in the first-unit linebacker group.
◆ Carson Hansen (TR: Iowa State)	RB	● Major Power 4 backfield piece	Doak Walker	Current first-unit/top-rotation back in a room replacing two NFL draftees.
◆ James Peoples (TR: Ohio State)	RB	● High-upside major-rotation back	Doak Walker	Provides talent and depth needed to replace the Singleton/Allen backfield without forcing Hansen into every carry.
◆ Brock Riker (TR: Texas State)	C	● Solid starting-center projection	Rimington	One of the few clearly identified anchors for an OL whose final five remains open.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderate by top-20 standards, with a forgiving September before a concentrated three-game contender test against USC, Michigan and later Washington.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Above average · SP+ SOS No. 59
Hardest stretch	Wisconsin -> at Northwestern -> USC -> at Michigan
Swing games	USC, at Michigan, at Washington
Advantage	Marshall, at Temple and Buffalo provide three games for the rebuilt roster to settle before Big Ten play; the bye follows the USC/Michigan back-to-back.
Expected	9.0 wins · most likely 9-3
Floor / ceiling	7-5 / 11-1

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Penn State is already respected at No. 17 SP+ / No. 18 AP, but the favorable path can make the final record look even stronger than the neutral-field profile; nine or ten wins do not require this to be the conference's fourth-best roster.
Back them when	The price does not fully credit the Becht/Mouser/Campbell continuity against opponents unable to exploit a rebuilding OL or front, especially after early games show the imported first unit functioning cohesively.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a premium before the OL five and transfer-heavy defense prove they can withstand top-tier line play, or when the market treats a top-20 model rating as if the continuity risk were already resolved.
Key monitor	final OL five, RB carry distribution between RB Carson Hansen/RB James Peoples, WR hierarchy, front-seven replacement quality, LB Tony Rojas workload after spring absence, QB2 order only for injury contingency
Week 1 baseline	vs. Marshall: rating-based fair baseline Penn State –26.0 ; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Penn State –24.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Penn State's top-20 projection survives an extraordinary roster reset because QB Rocco Becht and the Iowa State-derived coaching/offensive nucleus reduce the uncertainty of a normal rebuild. There is still quality at RB, TE, LB and special teams, but the offensive line and much of the receiving/defensive structure must be rebuilt around new combinations.

The upside is a forgiving first three games before the schedule sharpens; the risk is that **17 professional departures**, portal losses and low returning production overwhelm the imported continuity. Penn State can remain a contender-quality team, but the USC/Michigan stretch is the clearest test of whether the rebuild stabilized fast enough.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [fall camp](#) · [transfers](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [preseason recognition](#) · [position/camp update](#) · [Penn State Football Practice Observations](#)

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